
MURDER OF THE CZAR'S FAMILY: Complete Story of Their Imprisonment and Execution at Ekaterinburg—One of the Grimmiest Tragedies in the History of Royalty

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MURDER OF THE CZAR'S FAMILY

Complete Story of Their Imprisonment and Execution at Ekaterinburg—One of the Grimmiest Tragedies in the History of Royalty

NO grimmer or more tragic story than that told in the October issue of *CURRENT HISTORY* of the manner in which the former Czar of Russia and his entire family were slaughtered in cold blood in the remote Ural town of Ekaterinburg, it would seem, could be invented by the most morbidly imaginative of romancers. The Chamber of Horrors of the Russian epileptic, Dostoevsky, has nothing to equal it. That sombre and pathological genius, Leonid Andreiev, whose short stories of Russian life even went beyond those of Dostoevsky in their obsession by the horror of Russian life and the depths of the Russian soul, would have reveled in such a theme, had he lived to read the revelations only now being made of the way in which the Czar, the Czarina, their children and their personal attendants met their death in a remote provincial town on the outskirts of Siberia.

Even in the bare outline which was given in last month's issue of this magazine the story is as horrible as any story by Andreiev or Edgar Allan Poe. But the full story recently published in all details in *The London Times* masses in black shadows between the cold and naked lines, deepens, touch by touch, the impression of brooding fate, the horror of men's souls.

Those who read this story in full, even those who were hostile to the Czar and his Government during the Romanov régime and have not yet been convinced that the ruthless executions by which the Czar's reign was marked were permitted by the Czar through weakness of character, not through inherent cruelty, cannot but feel compassion for the innocent children who were included in the ghastly murders of the house of Ipatiev. Nor can they fail to be impressed by the unfailing courtesy, patience and humil-

ity of the Czar throughout the most cruel and degrading captivity which any deposed monarch ever had to face, by the Czarina's love of her sick boy, by her unfailing devotion to the man to whose downfall, through her blind cult for the sinister priest Rasputin, she had herself so powerfully contributed.

On the heads of this man and woman—the last representatives of Czardom—rested the ultimate responsibility for the woes of modern Russia, for the violent end of many Russian idealists, but they went to their own deaths like the aristocrats of the French Revolution: nobles they were, and nobles they remained to the very end. The quiet courtesy of their demeanor, their unshakable dignity and fortitude of soul, contrast powerfully with the brutality, the cruelty, the unspeakable obscenity of their Bolshevik guards and executioners.

Regarding the charges made in these articles that the whole plot was conceived and executed by Yankel Sverdlov, the head of the Central Executive Committee at Moscow, it is only fair to say that the evidence presented as yet is not conclusive. The official explanation of the Ekaterinburg Soviet, as well as that of the Soviet Government, is that the city of Ekaterinburg was threatened with occupation by the Czechs, who actually entered the city nine days after the execution, and that evidences had been gained of the existence of a monarchist plot to obtain possession of the prisoners. This explanation is accepted by Captain Francis MacCullagh in his fascinating psychological study of the Czar's last days, which appeared in the September issue of *Nineteenth Century*. Yurovsky, the Jewish shopkeeper and chief murderer, still lives on in Ekaterinburg, shunned and feared by all. A curious irony of fate is the fact that he now occupies the official post of Soviet In-

spector of Life Insurance for the Province of Ekaterinburg.

CZAR ACCUSED OF TREACHERY

The tragic story, as narrated by the author of *The Times* articles, opens before the revolution, when the many attacks made on the Czarina spread their poison throughout Russia. Her blind support of Rasputin won her universal hatred, and any one who lived in Russia during those final years knows how much this superstitious and hysterical cult did to undermine the power of the Romanovs. After the revolution, however, all the efforts of the Romanovs' active foes were concentrated on the deposed monarch. It was not enough that the Czar had abdicated: he must lose all love, all honor, so that he should never have a successor. So the sinister rumor was spread through Russia that the Czar and the Czarina had been secretly negotiating with the Germans. The Provisional Government did not combat it. The War Office in Petrograd suppressed the Czar's order of the day, in which the former Czar bade the soldiers farewell, declared his loyalty to the cause of Russia, and begged them never to lay down their arms against Germany.

It was due to this charge of treachery that the royal family, proclaimed prisoners of State at Tsarskoe Selo (March 21, 1917),* were treated like dangerous criminals, locked in separate rooms, forbidden all sight of or communication with one another, and forced to undergo the vilest insults from their guards. So, also, is explained the desertion of most of their former friends. Though Kerensky, after a thorough investigation,

had declared, "Tsar chist" (literally "The Czar is clean," equivalent here to innocent, above reproach), the revolutionary press did not retract its accusations.

THE REMOVAL TO SIBERIA

The Czar and his family were kept for five months in captivity at Tsarskoe Selo. During this time they suffered many humiliations. The whole family were spied upon, the palace was broken into, their trunks were looted. An officer accompanying Guchkov, the Minister of War, on one of his visits loudly declared that they had all sold out to the Germans. The ignorant soldiery expressed the Soviet attitude. They followed the Czar when he went out to exercise, they shot the Czarevitch's pet goats, and seized his toy rifle; they put on red badges and ignored the Czar's salute. Officers of the guard went into the dining room at lunch time to check off the prisoners. The Czar always greeted them. On one occasion an officer refused to take the Czar's outstretched hand. Deeply hurt the Czar asked "Why?" The officer put his hand behind his back. "I am of the people," he said. "When the people stretched their hands out to you, you did not meet them." The hardest thing in these words was their irrefutable truth.

At the end of July, 1917, the Provisional Government decided that the royal family must be removed from Tsarskoe. The Soviets of Petrograd and Kronstadt had already made efforts, lawful and unlawful, to gain possession of the prisoners. Once an individual in uniform appeared and on the strength of an order signed

*The record of events preceding this announcement of imprisonment had been briefly as follows: The Czarina, through her great influence over the weaker Czar, had led him to dismiss the Grand Duke Nicholas, and to take his place as Commander in Chief of the Army. This made it necessary for the Czar to leave Tsarskoe Selo, and to go to the Stavka (army headquarters). Freed from her ascendancy, the Czar began to do things which greatly troubled the Czarina; he listened to charges against the "Saint" (Rasputin) and even dismissed the Minister Stuermer. Rasputin's death helped the Czarina to regain her usual influence. But the Czar again departed to Moghilev, and the Empress was greatly worried. Her anxiety was increased by the sudden illness of her children, who all contracted measles in a serious form. Rumors of the revolution and that the Czar was about to abdicate made her frantic,

and she tried vainly to get into touch with him and to prevent the abdication. Her worst fears were realized. On the morning of March 21, the famous General Kornilov, who himself, soon after, was destined to meet a tragic end, came to inform Alexandra that it was his painful duty to announce that by decree of the Council of Ministers her Majesty must consider herself to be under arrest. This announcement was made in the children's playroom in the presence of Colonel Kobylinsky, the new Commandant of the Palace, whose devotion was subsequently shown after the royal family left Tsarskoe. The Czar arrived under custody. The meeting between the two sovereigns was an affecting one. They embraced tenderly, in the joy of reunion. Prison rules thenceforth prevented further communication, either with the outside world or with one another.



CZAR NICHOLAS II. AND HIS SON, THE GRAND DUKE ALEXIS, WHO, AT THE TIME THIS PICTURE WAS TAKEN, WAS PROSPECTIVE RULER OF ALL THE RUSSIAS BOTH FELL BEFORE BOLSHEVIST BULLETS IN THE DEATH CHAMBER AT EKATERINBURG

(Underwood & Underwood)

by Chkheidze, demanded that the captives be transferred to the Petrograd Fortress of SS. Peter and Paul. Colonel Kobylinsky averted this danger only with the greatest difficulty. Kerensky, realizing the seriousness of the situation, decided to remove the Czar and his family to Tobolsk, Siberia, chosen by him because of its remoteness. The Czar was not informed of his destination on receiving the notice of departure. Permission was given the banished sovereigns to choose the persons whom they wished to accompany them into exile. The final party selected included Ilya Leonidovich Tatischev and Prince Vasily Alexandrovich Delgoruky, Dr. Botkin, the young Countess Anastasia Vasilievna Gendrikovna, described as "an angel of purity and grace," Mlle. Schneider—a former Court lady who acted as the children's governess—and a retinue of servants.

The royal party was composed of the Czar, the Czarina, the three Grand Duchesses and the Czarevitch, Alexis.

The thirteenth birthday of young Alexis occurred just before departure. Prayers were offered. The girls and the boy were joyous at the prospect of a journey. The whole family went into the unknown, whose end was annihilation, filled with bright hopes of the future. At midnight on Aug. 13 Kerensky came to the palace and addressed the soldiers charged with guarding the party. "You have guarded the Czar's family here; you also will have to guard them in the new place where they are going, by order of the Council of Ministers. Remember, one does not hit a man who is down. Bear yourselves like men, not like cads," he said. Kerensky then entered the palace, and was present at a short interview between the Czar and

his only brother, the Grand Duke Michael, who were destined never to meet again.

THE JOURNEY TO TOBOLSK

The prisoners were obliged to wait until 6 o'clock in the morning for a train to bear them away, as the railway men at the station at Tsarskoe refused to let out the engine on hearing that the Czar's family was to be removed from Tsarskoe. At last they were off, thinking that they were going to the south. The Czar was troubled on hearing of his actual destination. For some reason he feared a trap, and Siberia, as it proved, was fated, indeed, to be a trap whose jaws would close over him and all his family. But neither the Czar nor Kerensky knew this at the time. The party traveled in comfort on sleeping cars with their retinue of servants. At Tiumen two steamers awaited the party for the river trip to Tobolsk. The steamer on its way passed the village of Pokrovskoe, the birthplace of the "Saint." The Czarina called her children to gaze on the banks of the stream in which the sinister monk in his youthful years had fished, and joined with them in prayer. To her superstitious imagination this passing of "Grishka's" birthplace was a mystical omen. The party reached Tobolsk on Aug. 19, within six days of departure. They were compelled to remain a whole week in the steamers, under constant guard, while the houses intended for them were being made ready. On Aug. 26 they moved into their new prison.

This consisted, for the whole party except the servants, of two houses, one the former residence of the Governor, a roomy stone building, the other adjacent, known as the Kornilov house. Both houses faced the main street of Tobolsk, which had been renamed Liberty Street. The ex-sovereigns and their children found lodgings in the upper story of the Governor's house. Here were located the Czar's study, the bedchambers of the imperial couple, and the drawing room. The schoolroom, the servants' rooms and the quarters of the military guard were downstairs. The Governor's house became overcrowded subsequently because

the soldiers dispossessed many of the servants in the Kornilov house with brutal disregard for the discomfort thereby caused to the imperial party.

Behind the house was a large inclosure, encircled by a high fence, where the family took their exercise; here the former Czar of All the Russias, like his royal cousin, the ex-Kaiser, in later days, chopped and sawed wood to relieve the tedium of confinement, and here he built a terrace where the family sat and chatted in the open air.

People passing by the Governor's house could see into the lower rooms. They would bow whenever they saw any member of the family at the windows and some would make the sign of the cross.

The life of the family was a simple and regular one during this period, made up of early rising (except in the case of the Czarina, whose heart trouble was so bad that she often stayed in her room until noon), school lessons for the children, exercise and woodchopping. The dinner at night was prepared by Kharitonov, the imperial cook. The family remained, reading or conversing, in the drawing room until 11 o'clock, when tea, according to the inveterate Russian custom, was served; soon afterward all lights were out. To relieve the monotony, the children took up private theatricals. The Empress was overjoyed because they were allowed to attend church. At Tsarskoe this had been forbidden. But this consolation was of short duration. The indiscretion of Father Vasiliev, the incumbent priest, who one day suddenly intoned prayers for the sovereigns, was punished by withdrawing the privilege of attending church, and thereafter the soldiers insisted on having one of their number on guard inside the house at all religious services, defeating the efforts of Colonel Kobylinsky to keep them out of the house.

Other misfortunes and indignities were in store for them. Special emissaries of the Provisional Government appeared a month after the royal family's arrival, one Komisar Pankratov,* and the other

* The diary of Pankratov, containing wholesale charges of ignorance and inefficiency against all the members of the Imperial Party, was published in the article by Capt Francis MacCullagh, above referred to.



CZARINA ALEXANDRA FEODOROVNA
*Last Empress of Russia, murdered, with her
 husband and son, by Bolsheviks*
 (Bain News Service)

his assistant. Nikolsky Pankratov had spent fifteen years in prison and twenty-five years in Siberian exile for his political activities, and was in high favor in revolutionary circles. Though he was a convinced anarchist, he was good-hearted, and was especially kind to the young Romanovs. His assistant, Nikolsky, on the contrary, was evil-tempered and tyrannical. He bore a special hatred to Alexis. Once, when some bottles of medicinal wine were sent to the Czarevitch, who was a chronic invalid, by permission of the Government, Nikolsky seized the bottles and shattered them all with sombre satisfaction.

As it turned out, however, the revolutionary theories of Pankratov were more

perilous to the royal exiles than the brutal persecutions of Nikolsky. Pankratov's exhortations had the effect of turning the ignorant soldiers into extreme Bolsheviks; they lost all respect for their superiors and began to maltreat the prisoners. The stream of obscene insults that followed the young Grand Duchesses until the final tragedy now began. Indecent drawings and inscriptions were scrawled on the posts of their swing. The soldiers compelled the Czar to cut off his Colonel's shoulderstraps, threatening violence when met with Kobylinsky's protests. Hurt and humiliated, the captive Czar complied. Thenceforth the only bond with Holy Russia was symbolized in his Cross of St. George, which, according to this account, he wore upon his breast until his dying day.*

In addition to their other troubles, the royal prisoners began to suffer from lack of money. Kerensky had promised funds, but no money had been received up to November. The faithful Dolgoruky and Tatischev spent all their own funds to maintain the household, then borrowed from kindly people in town on their personal notes. Two months later the Soviet Government curtly sent word that it would furnish no money. It added that the prisoners would be allowed their houses free of charge, and would receive soldiers' rations, but that if they wished any more they would have to work to earn it. The situation had to be faced. One-third of the servants were at once dismissed with a parting present from the depleted funds. From that time on it required much pinching and contriving to keep the royal family from starvation.

A NEW REMOVAL

At the end of March, 1918, Alexis had a severe attack of his congenital hip illness; both legs were paralyzed, and he lay ill and suffering for a month. At the end of that time his condition was somewhat improved, but he could not be moved without danger. It was at this juncture that a mysterious emissary from the Moscow Central Executive Committee arrived. His name was

* See, however, the following article.

Vasily Vasiliev Yakovlev. Yakovlev was a former Russian naval officer, of noble blood, who had been exiled for some political offense and had spent many years in Germany. He arrived on the evening of April 22 with an escort of 150 horsemen, and lodged in the Kornilov house. The order which he presented next day to Col. Kobylinsky was from the Tsik (the Central Executive Committee), and was signed by Sverdlov. It gave no idea of the nature of Yakovlev's mission, but commanded that he be given implicit obedience. Another order which Yakovlev showed the soldiers declared that any disobedience would be punished by death. At the same time Yakovlev announced to them, evidently to keep them quiet, that their pay had been raised from 50 kopecks, the rate fixed by the Kerensky Government, to three rubles a day.

On the 23d and 24th Yakovlev went repeatedly to the Governor's house, and on each occasion visited the room where the Czarevitch lay crippled, looked at him fixedly, and departed. On the night of the 24th he went to the telegraph office with an expert operator from Moscow and had a long conversation over the wire with Sverdlov, the substance of which, as afterward revealed, was the boy's illness, and the impossibility of removing him. Sverdlov ordered him to bring the Czar to Moscow, and to leave the boy behind.

Yakovlev then went to Colonel Kobylinsky, and for the first time revealed the object of his visit. He announced that he would depart the next day with the Czar, leaving the family behind. His haste was explained by the fact that the advent of Spring would soon make the roads and rivers impassable. Yakovlev, knowing the domineering character of the Czarina, insisted on seeing the Czar alone. The interview was set for 2 o'clock on the following day. When Yakovlev entered he was met by the Czarina, who, in a fury, with flashing eyes, demanded to know on what authority he sought to separate her from her husband. Yakovlev did not reply, but spoke directly to the Czar, explaining the nature of his orders. The Czar replied that he would not leave. Yakovlev then

said that if the Czar refused he (Yakovlev) would either have to use force or send in his resignation; in this event some one might be sent who would prove far less well disposed. He added that he would answer for the Czar's life and safety with his head. He bade the Czar be ready at 4 o'clock on the following afternoon and left the room without once addressing the Czarina.

THE CZARINA'S DECISION

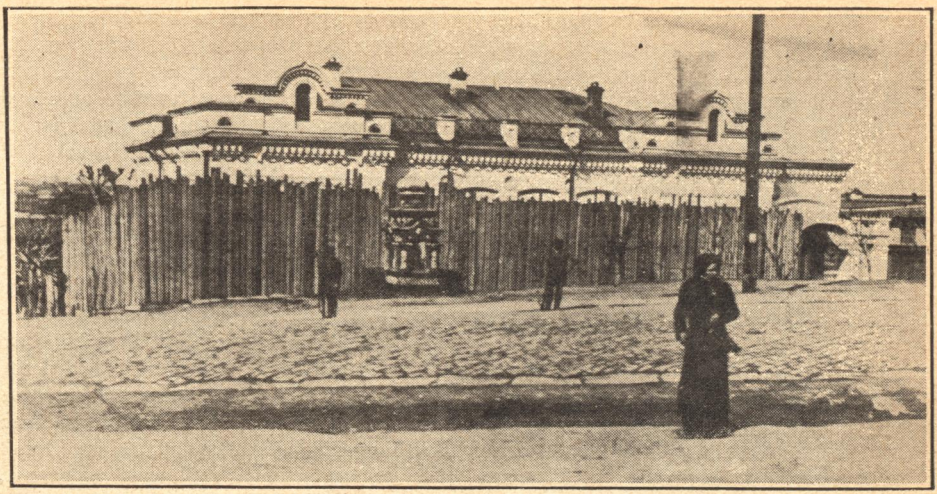
The group that remained behind consisted of the Czar and the Czarina, Tatischev, Dolgoruky and the Commandant, Kobylinsky. "Where do they want to take me?" asked Nicholas. Kobylinsky replied that Yakovlev had let escape the fact that he was taking the Czar to Moscow. The Czar said: "You see, they want me to sign the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk. But I would rather cut off my hand than do so." Alexandra declared: "I also am going. Without me they will persuade him into doing something, as they did once before." (She referred here to the abdication of the Czar.) For hours afterward, torn between her love for the sick boy and her duty to the Czar, she paced her room like a caged tigress. She finally sent for her favorite daughter, Tatiana, and, after a storm of weeping, said to her:

The Germans know that their treaty is valueless without the Czar's signature. * * * They want to separate him from his family in order to frighten him into some disgraceful act. * * * He will be afraid to refuse on our account.

After agonizing indecision, she jumped up, and cried: "It is enough. I go with the Emperor!" As Nicholas entered the room she said: "I shall not let you go alone." "As you will," was the reply of the dejected Czar. To Volkov, the Czarina's confidential manservant, Alexandra said: "Gosudar (literally Supreme Lord, the Czar) is to be taken away to Moscow. They want him to conclude peace. But I am going with him. I shall never permit such a thing. What would our allies say?"

THE PLOT OF VON MIRBACH

This, says the writer in *The Times*, was in harmony with previous utterances of the Czarina, who has often been



IPATIEV HOUSE AT EKATERINBURG, LAST RESIDENCE AND PRISON OF THE RUSSIAN IMPERIAL FAMILY, IN WHICH THE EXECUTION TOOK PLACE. IN THE NARROW SPACE BETWEEN THE FENCE AND THE HOUSE THE EX-CZAR TOOK HIS LAST WALKS



Bolsheviki who signed the Czar's death warrant: The central figure with cap in hand is Sosnovsky, a prominent Bolshevik connected with the Yurovsky family. On his right is Bykov, formerly an officer. Next to him is Beloborodov, President of the regional Soviet of Ekaterinburg. Standing behind Sosnovsky is Safarov, a member of the Executive Committee and a close associate of Lenin. At the extreme right of the first row is Goloschokin, also high in power. At the extreme left of the back row is Tuntul, a fanatical Bolshevik. The device on the red flag behind the group reads: "Soviet of Workmen's and Soldiers' Deputies." All these men signed the death warrant of Nicholas II. and his family. The picture was taken before epaulets had been abolished in the Bolshevik Army.

charged with being pro-German. On one occasion, when hearing from a newspaper that the Brest-Litovsk treaty contained a clause assuring the safety of the imperial family, she had cried out in French: "I would rather die in Russia than be saved by the Germans!" As it turned out, only the Germans could have saved her. According to the documents analyzed in the present article, both Sverdlov, at this time, and his representative, Yakovlev, were acting at the behest of Count von Mirbach, the German Ambassador to Moscow, who was planning secretly with a number of prominent Russians the restoration of the Russian Monarchy, and whose position in Moscow prior to his assassination was virtually that of a dictator. The original object was to get possession of the Czar and remove him to Moscow quietly before knowledge of the plan leaked out to any of the local Soviets upon the way. The haste of Yakovlev is partly to be explained upon this score.

Yakovlev made no objection to the Czarina's accompanying the Czar, nor to the other members of the party chosen. These included the Grand Duchess Marie, Prince Dolgoruky, Dr. Botkin and the valet Chemodurov, the maid Demidova and the boy Ivan Sedlev, the attendant and playmate of the sick Alexis. A number of soldiers were also chosen from the guard to forestall objections at the Czar's removal. The two other Grand Duchesses were left with various servants to watch over the sick Czarevitch.

EKATERINBURG REDS SEIZE CZAR

The vehicles provided for the journey to Tiumen, where the party was to take the train for Moscow, were like the ordinary Siberian *tarantass*, which consists of a large basket swung upon long flexible poles joining two springless axles. They were filled with straw, amid which the royal family disposed itself as well as possible. The Czarina had a *troika* (three-horse yoke), the others a pair of horses. Yakovlev insisted on being with the Czar and sent Marie to join her mother. The journey was a hard one because of the terrible conditions of the Springtime roads.

Often the party had to descend and wade through deep slush. Yakovlev pushed the horses to their utmost speed. It was already apparent that he was afraid of being stopped by local Soviets, and wished to gallop by the various towns before they had time to intercept him.

They reached Tiumen at 9 o'clock on the morning of the 29th and took the special train that was waiting there for them. The train started westward. They had not traveled far when Yakovlev heard at a wayside station that his fears of being stopped were well founded and that Ekaterinburg was planning to intercept him. He at once ordered the train to head east again as far as Omsk-Kulomzino, where he planned to connect with the Cheliabinsk-Ufa railway. His sudden flight was reported to the Ekaterinburg Soviet authorities, who wired to Omsk, and a cordon of Red troops stopped the train at Kulomzino. Yakovlev got out and went to Omsk, where, with the help of his expert telegraphist, he spoke with Sverdlov at Moscow.

At this juncture, according to The Times historian, the conspiracy conceived by Sverdlov to do away with the Czar became apparent. In full knowledge that the Ekaterinburg Red authorities intended to arrest the Czar and hold him, Sverdlov ordered Yakovlev to proceed via Ekaterinburg. The Red Guards of Ekaterinburg met them at the station on April 30. The Czar and his party were arrested. The Czarina lamented bitterly, weeping over her sick boy left behind in Tobolsk, and over her husband, for whose safety she now feared the worst.

The Soviet authorities of Ekaterinburg demanded of Yakovlev the formal surrender of the whole party. Yakovlev, who had been denounced by a man who called himself Zaslavsky* on the ground of treachery to the people, had no alternative, and was compelled to deliver up the captives. He received a written receipt, expressed as follows:

Russian Federal Soviet Republic, Uralian
Regional Council of Deputies. Receipt.

*Zaslavsky had spied on Yakovlev in Tobolsk. He was supported in his denunciation by a workman named Avdeiev, who, from the prominence thus gained, was subsequently appointed commandant of the death house in Ekaterinburg.

30th April, 1918.* I, the President of the Regional Uralian Council of Deputies, Beloborodov, have taken over from the member of the All-Russian Tsik Comrade Yakovlev, the interned: Former Czar Nicholas Romanov, the former Czaritsa Alexandra Feodorovna, the former Grand Duchess Marie Nikolaevna, and the persons accompanying them. All these persons are under arrest and under guard. The President of the Uralian Regional Sovdief. BELOBORODOV.

The royal prisoners were lodged by the Commissary Isai Goloshchekin—an intimate friend of Sverdlov—in the Ipatiev house. On arriving Goloshchekin pointed at the house and said dramatically: "Citizen Romanov, you may enter." He adopted the same procedure in the case of all the others. The party entered and disappeared from the sight of the world. They were in the power of the Red workmen of Revolutionary Russia, and the relentless jaws of the Bolshevik trap never relaxed their grip until the end.

OTHER ROMANOV'S BROUGHT FROM TOBOLSK

Meantime two other Commissaries, a sailor named Hohriakov and a certain Rodionov, a former frontier gendarme and spy on Russian revolutionaries in Berlin, went to Tobolsk to bring the remainder of the family to Ekaterinburg. The antithesis between Pankratov and Nikolsky had its parallel also here. Hohriakov was kind and good-natured, especially with the children; Rodionov tormented them. He forbade the Grand Duchesses to lock their doors at night, telling them, with an evil smile, that he had a right to enter their rooms whenever he liked. Before departure, the Grand Duchesses followed disguised instructions sent them in a letter from the maid Demidovna in Ekaterinburg, which told them to "dispose of the medicines as had been agreed." This referred to the family jewels, worth no less than a million gold rubles (\$500,000), which the mother and daughters had agreed, before the departure of the former to Ekaterinburg, should be carefully hidden. This is important, for it proved one of the means by which the murder of the whole royal family was proved. The Grand Duchesses sewed the

jewels up in their hats, in their bodices, and even inside their buttons, thus defying the formal search to which they, like the Czar, the Czarina and the Duchess Marie, were subjected before departure. The second party left Tobolsk on May 20, and reached Ekaterinburg on May 22 without incident. They were brought at once to the Ipatiev house, and interned with the other prisoners. The party now consisted of the reunited family, Dr. Botkin, four servants—the chambermaid Demidovna, the footman Trupp, the chef Kharitonov and the boy Leonid Sednev, attendant and playmate of the sick Alexis. Dolgoruky, Tatischin and the Countess Gendrikova had all been eliminated from the party by the Soviet authorities.* Chemodurov was taken away within three weeks, and lodged in the town jail.

THE IPATIEV HOUSE

The Ipatiev house stood at the corner of the avenue called Vosnesensky Prospekt and Vosnesensky Pereulok (lane), facing a large square in which stood the Church of the Ascension. The house was of stone, had two stories and a garden and outhouses behind. Access from the square was gained through a gateway. The lane sloped steeply down from the square, making the lower story of the house a semi-basement in front. The lower floor was taken by the guard; the prisoners were lodged upstairs in the corner rooms away from the stairs and entrance on the gate side. The Czar, the Czarina and the Czarevitch shared a room facing the square; the Grand Duchesses occupied the adjoining room overlooking the lane. Dr. Botkin and Chemodurov occupied one-half of another room divided by an arch, the servants another half.

Around the whole house, as stated, a wooden stockade had been erected, which reached to the windows of the upper floor. Soon after the party arrived, a new stockade was constructed which screened the house to the eaves, including the front entrance and the gateway. The panes of the windows were daubed with

*All three were separately imprisoned and sent off to Perm after the murder, where they were put to death several weeks later, together with the Grand Duke Michael.



THE ROOM AT EKATERINBURG IN WHICH THE CZAR AND HIS FAMILY WERE SHOT TO DEATH, JULY 17, 1918. THE PHOTOGRAPH SHOWS WHERE THE BULLET HOLES IN THE PLASTER WERE CUT OUT TO SERVE AS EVIDENCE

whitewash, making it impossible to look outside. Sentries, recruited from the workmen employed at the local mills and iron works, paced up and down at every point; inside the fences, in the garden, at the stairs, before the lavatory, on the terrace which overlooked the garden, and on which the dining room opened. Machine guns were posted here and at other points of vantage. The imperial family was in a trap from which there was no escape. They were under unceasing surveillance by day and night. Not even the girls were given the privacy that decency demanded. It was a martyrdom, a nightmare for the Romanov family, filled with more and more horrors.

DEGRADING EXPERIENCES

The commandant Avdeiev, who had received the sinister title of "Commandant of the Special Purpose House," lived with his assistants, Alexander Moshkin and Pavel Medvedov, both workmen, and his other associates in the upper story in close proximity to the prisoners. They subjected the Czar and his family to the utmost degradation which persons of refinement and breeding could experience. Drunken,

criminal types, human scum such as always floats on the surface of every revolution, they pried and searched and stole, forced their loathsome familiarities upon their helpless victims, sat side by side with them at table, elbowing them and lolling against them, nauseating them with the malodors of their unclean bodies, put their dirty hands in the plates, spat on the floor sonorously, sang obscene songs, wounded the modesty of the girls otherwise, with filthy scribbles and drawings on the walls and by crowding around the lavatory used in common by the prisoners and the guards, joking and commenting as they passed. Drunken, smoking, stealing, they reeled about the house, inspiring disgust and terror. So low had the Romanovs fallen.

The prisoners were allowed only a quarter of an hour daily in the open air. The Czar, who had had ample exercise and air at Tobolsk, suffered greatly from this confinement. The Czarina was overcome with their misfortunes. The boy remained a cripple, unable to walk. In this time of sorrow and degradation, their only consolation was re-

ligion, defined by the Bolsheviki on their official banners as "the opium of the people"; above the vile songs sung by the guards at night the voices of the family could be heard chanting the Song of the Cherubim, the Russian Gloria.

GUARDS UNDERGO CHANGE OF HEART

The final phase of the long agony was brought about indirectly through the Czar's friends and by the revelation that Avdeiev and his men, rough and brutal as they were, at last had been humanized by the spectacle of the sufferings and the patience and humility of their former sovereigns. This led to his immediate dismissal and the appointment of Yurovsky, the future "executioner," a man who proved himself a monster of savagery. Among the depositions taken by the investigators of the Czar's death was a statement by Yakimov, one of the guards under Avdeiev. He told how he had hated the Czar, to destroy whom he considered was to destroy capitalism itself, as the Social Democratic doctrine taught. But as he watched the "drinker of the people's blood" walking about the garden, conversing simply and naturally with the other guards, his hatred died away. "This," he thought, "is not a bad man; he is human, kindly, a man like other men, perhaps even better." Then the thought came to him that it was wrong to desire his death. Why not let them all escape, even the Czaritza, who was proud, not simple and kind like the Czar; if she had done wrong, she had also suffered. Russian reasoning this, in which the true spirit of the Russian people comes out strongly. This man repented of the vileness of the treatment which he and his fellows were giving to the Czar. He refused to join in with the other guards when they sang indecent songs, and argued with them and dissuaded them. Soon the whole guard, all workmen from the Lokalov and Syssert Companies' plants, were converted to this man's point of view and, with few exceptions, became disaffected.

This change of spirit was taken advantage of by one of the monarchist or-

ganizations, which sent a secret emissary to the Bishop of Ekaterinburg toward the end of June. This emissary, finding it would be impossible to get into communication with the imperial prisoners through the clergy, proposed that at least some food and comforts should be sent to the prison house. A Dr. De-revenko, who was in touch with the warders, gave his assistance. Avdeiev, touched by the new feeling of compassion for the suffering family, agreed to take in milk and other provisions that they could be sent to the house without attracting attention. He furthermore received personally the two novices of the monastery who, dressed in lay costume, brought supplies of dairy products to the house. The nuns, emboldened by Avdeiev's new attitude, came oftener and even brought tobacco for the Czar. Things looked brighter for the captives; hope once more dawned. Then came disaster.

THE ADVENT OF YUROVSKY

In some way the camarilla of Ekaterinburg, perhaps even Moscow, got wind of these new developments and of the disaffection of both Avdeiev and the guards. Avdeiev was at once dismissed, and the Russian guards transferred to premises across the lane; only Medvedev was allowed to retain his post as chief warder. Sentry duty was continued only for the outside posts, to deceive the public. These changes were made at the order of the new commandant, Yankel Yurovsky.

Yurovsky was a sinister and mysterious figure. He was a small shopkeeper in Ekaterinburg, the son of a Jewish convict. He had been in the pay of the Germans, and had become one of the chiefs of the local Extraordinary Council (for combating the counter-revolution). His appointment brought doom to the captives. He installed a squad of ten so-called "Letts," who acted as guards and took charge of the machine guns. It has long been believed that these men were Letts, but the official investigation disclosed the fact that they were Magyars, some of them Magyarized Germans. It is surmised that they were former Austrian soldiers who

helped in the sovietizing of Russia and entered the Extraordinary Council in order to further the German design of undermining Russia. However this may be, a considerable number of proofs exist that they were not Letts, but Hungarians. The Russian guards saw from their speech that they were foreigners. It was natural to suppose them Letts, it is true, because the Letts were the backbone of the Soviet's foreign mercenaries. Furthermore, the Magyars resemble the Letts in appearance and accent; there is even a racial relation between them. Yurovsky, who knew only Russian, Yiddish and German, spoke to them in a foreign language. One of these "Letts" left an unfinished letter in Magyar to his "tereschen." It was filled with mistakes, and was evidently the Magyar of a Magyarized German. Another wrote his name, András Verhás, followed by the Magyar word "örsegen" (guard duty), which he had tried to translate into Russian (karaul), but could not spell out. On scraps of paper other guards had practiced writing Russian words.

Yurovsky and these hired assassins were in control when the nuns made their last visit bearing provisions to the captives. This last visit occurred on July 10, 1918, about a week before the murder. Some of the transferred Russian guards looked confused, and were unwilling to take the gifts. They finally did so, and the nuns started away. They were recalled to the presence of Yurovsky. He inquired their authority for bringing the provisions. They answered they had come by the authority of Avdeiev and Derevenko. "Oh, they are both in it, are they?" Yurovsky said, ominously. He allowed them, however, to come again, but to bring only milk.

APPROACHING DOOM

Yurovsky and his band watched the captives as a cat watches a mouse. Their sinister intentions were revealed by their every word and attitude. The appointed executioners, the author of *The Times'* articles says, were only awaiting the signal from Sverdlov, the spider who had spun his web in Moscow. Yurovsky oft-

en went on absences that lasted many hours. Several witnesses deposed to meeting him and his bodyguard of "Letts" in the woods during this last week, near the spot where the remains of the imperial family were afterward destroyed. Medvedev was always left in charge, under the espionage of one Nilukin. On Monday, July 15, the nuns brought milk for the captives. Yurovsky graciously told them they might bring half a hundred eggs on the following day. They did so joyously. The eggs were boiled by the imperial chef, but others ate them, not in the Ipatiev house, but in the woods near Kupchiki, where for three days and nights the frightful work of destruction was carried on.

On Tuesday morning Yurovsky made his final preparations for the murder of the whole imperial family. The boy, Leonid Sedlev, was removed to a house across the lane where the Russian guard had been transferred. He was last seen crying—then he disappeared and was never seen again. Yurovsky went out in company with the Commissary Goloschekin and Beloborodov, President of the local Soviet. He returned toward evening. At 7 o'clock he ordered Medvedov to collect all the revolvers of the guard. Medvedov collected twelve Nagans (the Russian service revolvers) and brought them to Yurovsky's room. Yurovsky then revealed his plan to kill the whole imperial family that night. He told Medvedov to maintain secrecy and to warn the Russian guards only when the word came. This word came at about 10:30. The guards, already implicated by actions equivalent to counter-revolution, made no protest. Two strangers meanwhile arrived at the house. One, Peter Ermakov, military commissary of the Verkh-Isetak ironworks; the other, his assistant, a sailor named Vaganov. These men had distinguished themselves for their ferocity as leaders in the Red terror. Both were friends of Yurovsky, and the evidence shows that they had agreed with the latter to undertake the disposal of the bodies.

At midnight the final scene in the sombre drama began. Yurovsky went to the imperial chambers. The family slept. He awoke them, told them there

would be fighting in the city, that they must be removed at once, and that they must dress quickly and come downstairs. They all rose, washed and dressed themselves to go out. The Grand Duchesses donned their garments, heavy with the hidden jewels. The Czarina wore her coat. Some of the prisoners even took their pillows, for greater comfort on the imagined journey before them.

Yurovsky, according to this account, led the way downstairs. The Czar is said to have carried the crippled Alexis in his arms. Dr. Botkin followed, after him came the chambermaid, Demidova; the cook, Kharitonov; and the footman, Trupp. They descended by the back stairs leading to the ground floor. The door leading to the rooms of the ground floor had been boarded up in order to prevent the disaffected Russian guards from communicating with the Czar. The party, therefore, had to go out into the yard and re-enter by a separate doorway. In the dim light they could see the motor lorry waiting, which they supposed would take them to a place of safety. Yurovsky led the way through the rooms of the lower floor to the small lobby in the corner on the lane side. Outside the small grated window which gave light stood a sentry with a machine gun. This man could see everything that occurred within this corner basement, which was lighted for the execution. His testimony subsequently confirmed many of the depositions dealing with the murder. A locked door led into a basement chamber, situated immediately under the Czar's prison room.

The family were shown into this room and told to wait. Chairs were asked for by the Czar. Only three were brought: on these sat the Czarina, the Czar and the Czarevitch. A pillow was placed behind Alexandra. The maid, Demidovna, held the other two pillows. Three of the Grand Duchesses stood on their mother's right, the other daughter and Demidovna on her left.

THE MURDER OF THE IMPERIAL FAMILY

Suddenly Yurovsky, who had gone out, returned, and appeared in the door, into which he and his friends and the

"Letts" crowded after him. Besides Yurovsky, there were Nikulin, Ermakov, Vaganov, Medvedev, and seven "Letts," the other three remaining on guard duty. In all there were twelve murderers. Each carried a revolver. The rifles of the "Lett" guard were stacked in the adjoining room, where they lived.

Yurovsky stepped forward and addressed the Czar. The most trustworthy version of what he said is as follows:

Your relatives have tried to save you. But it could not be managed by them, and so we ourselves are compelled to shoot you.

The revolvers were leveled and discharged. The Czar, the Czarina, three of the children, Dr. Botkin and two servants (Kharitonov and Trupp) were instantly killed. One of the girls, presumably the youngest, Anastasia, writhed and screamed, and fought the guard who approached and killed her. Demidovna, the maidservant, perhaps because protected by the pillows, was not touched by the first volley, and ran about the room screaming, till the Letts seized their rifles and bayoneted her to death with many stabs. Within a few minutes of their entering the death chamber all was over.

So perished the royal family of the Romanovs. Yurovsky and his associates hurried desperately to efface all signs of the crime. Though officially authorized to commit the deed, they knew that their "execution" of the Romanovs would not be considered lawful by the people. The floors and walls, covered with pools and splashes of blood, were summarily washed. The motor lorry, under charge of Ermakov and Vaganov, took away the corpses.

WITNESSES OF CRIME

In the volume of evidence collected by Sokolov and Gen. Diedrichs are contained the depositions of three eyewitnesses of the crime. One of these eyewitnesses was Paul Medvedev, another was the "converted" sergeant, Anatol Yakimov, and a third was a Red Guard named Proskuriakov, who helped to remove the traces. Medvedev told his wife all that had occurred immediately after the murder. He boasted that he was the only

Russian workman who had taken part in the shooting, and that all the others, apart from Yurovsky and his assistants, were "not ours"—in other words, were foreigners. Medvedev was caught later at Perm while trying to blow up the bridge over the Kama behind the retreating Red army. When arrested and questioned, he confirmed all the details given by him to his wife, but insisted that he had not taken part in the shooting, and concocted an alibi. Yurovsky, he said, just before the murder was committed, had sent him out to see if any one was around, and whether the shots could be heard. On his way out he heard the shots and immediately returned:

I saw that all the members of the Czar's family—the Czar, the Czarina, the four daughters, and the Naslednik (heir) were already lying on the floor with numerous wounds on their bodies, and the blood was flowing in torrents. The doctor, maid, and two menservants had also been killed. When I appeared the Naslednik was still alive, groaning. Yurovsky went up to him and fired two or three times point blank into him. The Naslednik was still. The picture of the murder, the smell and sight of the blood made me feel sick.

Yakimov, the second witness, was the guard whose "conversion" through the spectacle of the Czar's sufferings and through observation of the Czar's character has been described above. He retained his post as sergeant of the guard after the other members were transferred. There is good reason to believe that he was present at the murder. His evidence was full and circumstantial, and corroborated that of Medvedev in every detail. Like Medvedev, he offered an alibi, declaring that he had been told of what occurred by the two sentries outside the window and by two others in the courtyard when the bodies were taken out. He declared that he heard of the murder only at 4 o'clock in the morning, and that for the rest of the night he was unable to sleep, but "just sat and shivered."

At 8 o'clock in the morning he went to his sister, the wife of an official of the Commissariat of Justice named Agafonov. His sister testified that he was very much upset; that his face was convulsed and his body trembling. When she ques-

tioned him he admitted that he had seen the spectacle with his own eyes, and that he had been so shaken that he had had to go out several times to get the open air. After his departure the sister ran at once to her husband, and told him the story. She was weeping and overcome with horror. Her husband repeated the tale afterward to an investigating Magistrate named Tomashevsky. Later in the day Yakimov came to take leave of Agafonov. He was going to the front. His face was so convulsed that Agafonov was convinced that the story he had told his sister was true. When he asked him about it Yakimov replied only: "*Vse koncheno.*" (It is all over.)

Proskuriakov, whose type is that of the young, good-natured peasant, deposed that he had entered the guard from curiosity to see the Czar. He had spent the evening drinking "denaturat" (methylated spirits) with friends, and had been placed under arrest by Medvedev. The latter came to the bathhouse where he was sleeping off the effects of the liquor, and ordered him to help wash the blood stains from the floor and walls. The bodies had already been removed. The details of the murder were told him by one of the guards named Strekotin, who told the same story without change to a brother guard, Letemin. Letemin was arrested later, and found to be in possession of a number of valuables belonging to the family. Proskuriakov also deposed that Medvedev told the story to him and to the other guards who were washing the floor. Medvedev, he declared, had admitted that he had taken part in the shooting, and had not said a word about having been sent outside.

DISPOSITION OF THE BODIES

We now reach the last episode in the tragic tale, which concerns the destruction of the bodies. The evidence makes gruesome reading. In reconstructed form the account is as follows:

The murder accomplished, all the bodies were carried into the courtyard and placed on the waiting motor lorry. They were rolled up in old coats and covered with mats, to deceive all curious eyes. Yurovsky, Ermakov and Vaganov went with the ghastly load, leaving Med-

vedev to supervise the efforts to remove all accusing traces. The lorry's first destination was the Verkh Isetsk iron-works, adjoining the city, along the route to Koptiaki, northeast of Ekaterinburg. Just a few miles beyond lay the Stenbok-Fermor woods, where the last gruesome task was accomplished. Ermakov lived at these iron works where, before departing to the death house, he had left certain orders as military commissary. When the lorry arrived, Ermakov found, according to his instructions, a detachment of Red Guards waiting with a number of conveyances ready for departure. The lorry started out again with these new escorts and moved along the Koptiaki road. Vaganov had left the lorry, and on horseback acted as an armed guard for the lorry.

The procession, shortly after 3 o'clock in the morning, reached a point where several long disused and grass-grown paths converge to the left toward a place called Ganina Yama (Ditch), where a deep mining shaft was situated. This was chosen as the place for the destruction of the bodies, and a cordon of Red soldiers was thrown around the whole wood. During that day and the two following days and nights all passage through the wood was stopped. As a result of this barrier a crowd of fisher folk and vacationists, striving to reach Koptiaki, a pretty place which attracted many Summer residents, collected at the level crossing over the Ural line. The establishment of this cordon greatly aroused the curiosity of the peasants, who hastened to the spot immediately after the cordon was raised, and whose evidence afforded immense and valuable service to the later investigation. The further narrative may be reconstructed from the findings of the investigation as follows:

GHASTLY LABORS

Having reached the chosen spot, the regicides partly undressed the bodies. The bodices of the Grand Duchess Olga, Tatiana and Anastasia attracted their attention by their weight. They tore them apart and spilled the costly jewels concealed therein upon the ground. Some of them rolled into the grass and were

trodden into the soil of the clay mound that surrounded the pit's mouth. Around the neck of the Grand Duchess Olga they found a satchel containing special gems, and around her shoulders several ropes of pearls. They then set to work to hack the partly denuded bodies to pieces on the mound, in doing which they smote and cleft some of the valuables that still remained. Their next step was to soak the dismembered remains in sulphuric acid, large quantities of which had been brought from Ekaterinburg in order to dissolve the larger bones, after which they dipped them in oil and threw them into two pyres which had been built and lighted, one near the shaft, the other near a birch tree. The clothes of the victims were also burned. All the cinders were then collected and thrown down the shaft of the mine, which had been previously prepared. The bottom of the shaft was so deep that ice remained in it throughout the Summer. This ice was smashed with hand grenades, and the cinders and last remains sank to the bottom beneath the water. A flooring was then adjusted over them and firmly fixed. The murderers, with the exception of Yurovsky, who motored back and forth from Ekaterinburg in company with Goloshchekin on the 17th, 18th and 19th, remained in the wood until their ghoulish work was done. Innumerable witnesses saw them coming and also saw them leaving, rolling about in the lorry, like men weary to death.

Thus the unspeakably grisly crime was consummated. Meanwhile the whole Ipatiev house was plundered and everything discarded thrown into the fireplaces, whose fires were kept blazing. The guards were continued throughout this whole period around the death house, so that the people suspected nothing. They were removed only on the fourth day, when the cordon around the wood was raised.

We now come to the elaborate efforts allegedly made by the Soviet Government to conceal the real facts in the case and to whitewash its own guilt. The author of the account herein analyzed says:

There has probably not been another instance in the whole history of crime

of precautions to escape detection half so elaborate as in the Romanov murder case. All sorts of subterfuges have been tried by lesser criminals with more or less success. Here every ruse was combined. The murderers carried out the following comprehensive program: (1) They gave out a false announcement of the "execution"; (2) they destroyed the bodies; (3) they invented a mock funeral, and (4) they staged a mock trial. But the very complexity of the Soviet "precautions" proved their undoing. In vain they suborned false witnesses to give misleading information of the whereabouts of the bodies, announcing officially that the family had been removed to a "safe place," &c. * * * Sokolov has run them into the open.

THE FALSE ANNOUNCEMENT

Only on July 20, 1918, was the announcement made at the meetings and in official proclamations that "Nicholas the Bloody" had been executed. The wireless stations of the Bolshevik Government flashed the news abroad. The official announcement was couched in the following terms:

At the first session of the Central Executive Committee elected by the Fifth Congress of the Councils a message was made public, received by direct wire from the Ural Regional Council, concerning the shooting of the ex-Czar, Nicholas Romanov.

Recently Ekaterinburg, the capital of the Red Ural, was seriously threatened by the approach of the Czechoslovak bands. At the same time a counter-revolutionary conspiracy was discovered, having for its object the wresting of the tyrant from the hands of the council's authority by armed force. In view of this fact, the Presidium of the Ural Regional Council decided to shoot the ex-Czar, Nicholas Romanov. This decision was carried out on July 16.

The wife and son of Romanov have been sent to a place of security. Documents concerning the conspiracy which were discovered have been forwarded to Moscow by a special messenger.

It had been recently decided to bring the ex-Czar before a tribunal to be tried for his crimes against the people, and only later occurrences led to delay in adopting this course. The Presidency of the Central Executive Committee, after having discussed the circumstances which compelled the Ural Regional Council to take the decision to shoot Nicholas Romanov, decided as follows: The Russian Central Executive Committee, in the persons of the Presidium, accept the decision

of the Ural Regional Council as being regular.

The Central Executive Committee has now at its disposal extremely important material concerning the Nicholas Romanov affair, his own diaries, which he kept almost to the last days; the diaries of his wife and children, his correspondence, among which are letters by Gregory Rasputin to Romanov and his family. All these materials will be examined and published in the near future.

On the basis of the official documents of investigation placed in his hands by Sokolov, the author of The Times articles declares that every statement contained in this official Soviet announcement is false, showing up in more glaring colors the diabolical nature of the plot conceived and carried out by Sverdlov and his accomplices. First of all, the alleged message from the Ural Council was concocted by Sverdlov himself. The Czechs did enter Ekaterinburg, but not until July 25, nine days after the "execution." There is no evidence of an armed plot to liberate the ex-Czar. The Presidium of the Ural Council did not "decide" to shoot the Czar, for that "decision" was dictated from Moscow by Sverdlov. The Czarina and the Czarevitch were not sent to a place of security, but were foully murdered. There was no intention to bring the Czar to trial before an official tribunal. The alleged "later occurrences" were fictitious. The "important material," including diaries and correspondence, it is implied, were never intended to be published, and have not been published to this day.

In Ekaterinburg an official announcement duplicating the message read before the Tsik was issued, and another announcement signed by Sverdlov approving the "execution" was similarly published. This second announcement read as follows:

Decision of the Presidium of the All Russian Centr. Ex. Com. of 18th July, A. C. The All Russian Centr. Ex. Com. of Soviets of W. P. R.* and Cossack Deputies in the person of its Presidium approves the action of the Presidium of the Reg. Sov. of the Ural.

(Signed) The President of the Tsik,
Y. SVERDLOV.

*Evidently Workmen's and Peasants' Republic.—Ed. Note.

The date given shows that this decision of approval was kept back for two days after its ostensible issue. The official evidences demonstrate, says The Times correspondent, that the very text of the Ekaterinburg announcement had been dictated and approved by Sverdlov.

THE MOCK FUNERAL

The next step in the work of deception was the invention of a mock funeral to influence public opinion in Russia and abroad. The official Soviet organ, *Isvestia*, according to a telegram from Moscow to The London Times on Sept. 23, 1918, published the following account, false from start to finish:

The body of the ex-Czar, which had been buried in a wood at the place of execution, was exhumed, the grave having been found through information supplied by persons who were acquainted with the circumstances of the execution. The exhumation took place in the presence of many representatives of the supreme ecclesiastical authorities in Western Siberia, the local clergy and delegates from the People's Army, Cossacks and Czechoslovaks. The body was placed in a zinc coffin, incased in a costly covering of Siberian cedar, and the coffin was exposed in the Cathedral at Ekaterinburg under a guard of honor composed of the chief commanders of the People's Army. The body will be temporarily buried in a special sarcophagus at Omsk.

THE MOCK TRIAL

Comment on this solemn farce is unnecessary. The last link in the chain of deception was forged with the holding of a mock trial. A whole year later, in September, 1919, owing to the pressure of public opinion and the gradual divulgence of the real facts, the Bolsheviks staged at Perm an ostensible "trial," which aimed to clear them of all responsibility, despite the fact that they had officially approved the execution of the Czar as regular. This "trial" is stated to have been held on Sept. 17, 1919, in the House of the Executive Committee of the Perm Soviet. The proceedings were reported in the Bolshevik paper *Pravda*† as follows:

The Revolutionary Tribunal has considered the case of the murder of the late Czar Nicholas Romanov, his wife, the Princess of Hesse, their daughters Olga

(Tatiana), Marie and Anastasia, and their suite. In all eleven persons were assassinated. Of the twenty-eight persons accused three were members of the Ekaterinburg Soviet — Grusinov, Yakhontov and Malutin; among the accused were also two women, Maria Apraksina and Elizaveta Mironova. The account of the murder as gathered from the material under the consideration of the Revolutionary Tribunal is as follows:

The Czar and all the members of his entourage were shot—no mockery and no cruelties took place. Yakhontov admitted that he had organized the murder in order to throw the discredit of the crime on the Soviet authorities, whose adversary he became after having joined the Socialist revolutionaries of the Left Wing. The plan of murdering the Czar was conceived during the latter's stay at Tobolsk, but the Czar was too strictly watched. In Ekaterinburg, when the Czechoslovak troops were approaching the town, the Soviet authorities were panic-stricken to such a degree that it was easy for him to avail himself of his position as Chairman of the Extraordinary Commission (for combating counter-revolution) and to give the order to murder the Czar and his family. Yakhontov admitted that he personally participated in the murder, and that he took upon himself the responsibility for it. He, however, said that he was not responsible for the robbery of the belongings of the Czar's family. According to his deposition, Czar Nicholas said before he died: "For the murder of the Czar Russia will curse the Bolsheviks." Grusinov and Malutin stated that they did not know anything about Yakhontov's plans and only carried out his orders. Yakhontov was found guilty of the murder and sentenced to death. Grusinov, Malutin, Apraksina and Mironova were found guilty of robbery committed on the murdered members of the Czar's family. They were sentenced to death, too. The death sentence was carried out the following day.

Several objects belonging to the household of the Czar were discovered with a thief named Kiritshevsky, who stated that these things had been given to him by a man named Sorin, who was the Chairman of the Local Extraordinary Commission. At the time of the murder Sorin was the commander of a revolutionary battalion. Sorin was a personal friend of Beloborodov, who also participated in the assassination of the Emperor.

Not one of the names mentioned, except that of Beloborodov, says the publisher of this official account, bears any resemblance to any on the list of 164 persons mentioned in the official dossier as having been implicated in the crime,

†Reproduced by the Russian paper *Rossia* (Paris) No. 1, on Dec. 17, 1919.

or even under suspicion. The twenty-four members of the Ekaterinburg Sovdief are known; not one of the men mentioned appeared on it. The name Yakhontov cannot be identified with that of Yurovsky. Beloborodov, stigmatized in the *Pravda* as a thief, had been promoted to the Tsik—the highest honor obtainable in Soviet Russia—for the very assassination for which he was subsequently denounced, and which, according to the official dossier of the investigation, he had carried out at the order of the Tsik itself. With this concoction of a “trial” of the alleged murderers of the whole imperial family working, as declared, to discredit the Soviet Government, the whole solemn farce is complete, and the last effort of the Soviet Government to clear its own skirts is consummated.

INVESTIGATORS' TASK COMPLETED

The long, devoted and unremitting labors of Sokolov and General Diedrichs to trace the history of the crime have been described in the October issue of *CURRENT HISTORY*. Hundreds of witnesses were examined, hundreds of clues followed down, leading from the death chamber to the Ural wood where the bodies were destroyed. Having established, with the evidences of accomplices and inspection of the “death-house,” the fact that a murder had been committed, the investigating magistrate had either to find the bodies or to prove what had become of them.

This proved to be a task of tremendous difficulty. Having located the scene of the destruction, it was necessary to obtain miners with pumping machinery, woodsmen and surveyors to examine the shaft and study the ground. These new forces, as well as the necessary funds, were provided by the late Admiral Kolchak out of his own means. Under the orders and direction of General Diedrichs a considerable force of White

Guards was formed to carry out the necessary operations. The men were all miners and peasants versed in woodcraft from the Urals. Several hundreds camped around the Ganina Yama (ditch). These men worked with intense energy. All traces of the work of destruction were uncovered. The false bottom of the shaft was revealed, the contents extracted with infinite labor. There were literally hundreds of proofs now available, including many of the remaining jewels, articles of clothing and other personal belongings of the murdered family. The complete collection was examined and classified by Sokolov; it is given in full in the dossier published in *The Times*. Many of the exhibits were afterward identified by witnesses.

The whole crime thus stood at last revealed. All the efforts of the Soviet Government to cover up the facts, and to absolve itself from guilt in connection with them, are declared by this chronicler to have been demonstrated false by the relentless and innumerable evidences contained in the Sokolov dossier. The full story of how the Soviet authorities of Ekaterinburg consummated one of the most brutal regicides of history has been at last published to the entire civilized world. It will be left to the judgment of history after handing down the passionless, inexorable record of how the whole imperial family of the Romanovs was done to death by Bolshevik leaders in the basement room of a remote provincial town in Siberia, how their helpless bodies were hacked to pieces in an obscure wood, then burned and their ashes buried at the bottom of a mining shaft, and to decide finally and irrevocably whether or not, as these articles declare, the official Government of Russia plotted the infamy and subsequently falsified, by every means in its power, the actual truth.

